

Upendrra Rai: The Strategic Mind Behind One of India's Fastest-Growing News Networks



Upendrra Rai

Chairman, Managing Director, and Editor-in-Chief
Bharat Express News Network

In an era marked by rapid information flow and heightened public scrutiny, the role of journalism has evolved beyond reportage into one of responsibility, balance, and public trust. Upendrra Rai, Chairman, Managing Director, and Editor-in-Chief of Bharat Express News Network, stands as a defining figure in this transformation, one who has consistently aligned editorial leadership with national consciousness and institutional integrity. With over 28 years of experience in Indian journalism, Upendrra Rai's professional journey reflects intellectual depth, operational foresight, and a sustained commitment to ethical media practices. A journalist by vocation and a thinker by temperament, he is also a respected writer, orator, and motivator whose influence extends beyond newsrooms into policy dialogue, youth engagement, and cultural discourse. Upendrra Rai's career spans some of India's most prominent media institutions, including Sahara News Network, Star News, CNBC-Awaaz, and Tehelka. His tenure as CEO and Editor-in-Chief at Sahara India Media and Tehelka added strategic and editorial dimensions to his already accomplished reporting career. Over the years, he became closely associated with investigative journalism, examining complex subjects related to governance, public accountability, and financial transparency, work that consistently resonated with national audiences. Recognizing early shifts in media consumption and the growing importance of independent platforms,

he founded The Printlines Media Group, laying the groundwork for a future-oriented media ecosystem. This vision culminated in the launch of Bharat Express News Channel in 2023, a decisive step toward building a multi-platform, high-impact news organization. Under Upendrra Rai's leadership, Bharat Express News Network has experienced accelerated growth in television viewership and digital reach, positioning itself among India's fastest-growing news networks. The channel's editorial philosophy emphasizes accuracy, impartiality, and timeliness, principles that have helped it earn credibility across diverse demographics. Programming on Bharat Express reflects a strong alignment with national priorities, cultural values, and constructive public dialogue. Its digital platforms have further strengthened engagement by offering breaking news, current affairs coverage, and in-depth analysis, ensuring relevance in a digitally driven media environment. Expansion plans into print and business media are already underway, reinforcing the network's ambition to become a comprehensive media institution. Beyond daily news operations, Bharat Express has successfully organized more than ten large-scale conclaves under Upendrra Rai's stewardship, creating platforms for dialogue on governance, economy, culture, and youth participation. Flagship initiatives such as the Bharat Literature Festival and the Ghazipur Literature Fest have brought together prominent voices from the fields of film, media, and literature, reflecting wide participation from across the creative and intellectual spectrum. In addition, Kavyanjali, conceived as a literary tribute to the celebrated poet Gopal Das Neeraj, stands as a thoughtful homage to his enduring contribution to Indian literature. Upendrra Rai's engagement with ideas extends into authorship. His books, Hastakshep and Nazariya (Both in Hindi), reflect analytical depth and social awareness, offering readers perspectives on contemporary issues through the lens of lived journalistic experience. These works reinforce his reputation as a media professional who values reflection as much as action. His engagement with young people has been marked by direct interaction and dialogue across various platforms and public engagements. Often invited to connect with students and emerging professionals, Upendrra Rai has

interacted with the youth," where discussions have focused on education, media literacy, evolving career pathways, and the responsibilities that accompany an informed and aware society. These interactions underscore his belief in constructive conversation and mutual learning, rather than one-way discourse. Rooted in his native village, Upendrra Rai's philosophy of social contribution is guided by a principle he often articulates: what one gains from education must be returned to society. Translating belief into action, he donated ₹50 lakhs to his village school for the establishment of a library and supporting educational facilities, an initiative designed to expand access to knowledge for future generations. His environmental contributions are equally substantial. By participating in Prime Minister Narendra Modi's initiative "Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam," and facilitating the planting of trees, he demonstrated a sustained commitment to ecological balance and community well-being. Upendrra Rai's contributions to journalism and public life have been acknowledged through numerous national and international honors. These include the Star Achiever Award (2006), Star Patrakar Ratna Puraskar (2007), Indian Television Academy Award for Best Performance in Hindi News Channels (2007), Bharosa Patrakar Samman, National Unity Award (2010, Hubli), Dr. APJ Abdul Kalam Award for Iconic Media Personality, Lions Club Award for Social Service, and the National Excellence Award from the World Book of Records, London (2019). In 2024, he was conferred with the National Chetna Award at the Global Summit. As Chairman and Editor-in-Chief, Upendrra Rai continues to steer Bharat Express News Network with clarity of purpose and institutional discipline. His leadership model integrates editorial independence with organizational growth, ensuring that expansion does not compromise credibility. Looking ahead, his vision for Bharat Express is firmly aligned with the evolving needs of New India, building platforms that inform responsibly, encourage meaningful dialogue, and contribute constructively to democratic discourse. In doing so, Upendrra Rai is not merely expanding a media network; he is shaping a legacy of journalism grounded in integrity, insight, and service to society.